DIVERGENT THINKING: Sample “Be Creative” Instructions

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We’ve argued in many papers that divergent thinking tasks are ambiguous as measures of creativity unless people are instructed to “be creative.” We find that it helps to belabor this point to participants, both in your oral instructions to them and in written instructions attached to the task. To get you started, here’s an example of one way to get the point across:

> For this task, you'll be asked to come up with as many original and creative uses for a BRICK as you can. The goal is to come up with ***creative ideas***, which are ideas that strike people as clever, unusual, interesting, uncommon, humorous, innovative, silly, or different. The uses for a BRICK don’t have to be realistic or practical—creative ideas are often silly or bizarre.
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> You can enter as many ideas as you like; just press ENTER after each one. The task will take 3 minutes. You can type in as many ideas as you like until then, but it is more important to come up with creative ideas than a lot of ideas—quality is more important than quantity.